in the company (maybe in the Army) in physical conditioning.

There was nothing I could do without falling apart. I hit rock bot-

8 1 wasn't there and I don't know how accurate the lieutenant was in making his report to me.

torn in the running test. They ran us five at a time and a fellow stood near the finish line with a stopwatch calling off numbers as each person passed the line. Somehow they matched time and soldier but I don't know how, for I was tensely waiting my turn.

Four others and I finally started off and the man at the finish line called out four times, realized no one else was passing, and shouted, "Next five!"

"Wait!" cried a medley of voices, and the time man looked up in surprise and found I was still trying to reach the finish line. I was walking.

That day we were also issued gas masks, though gas had not been used at any time in World War II. We had to march with gas masks on and I simply could not pump enough air through the absorbent. It was either strangle to death with the gas mask on, or take it off. I took if off. I would probably have been court-martialed and shot if I had been caught at it.

Later on, we were forced to smell samples of various poison gases, just in case we were called upon to fight World War I again. I held my breath till out of range.

We also spent some days on the rifle range, where for the first and last time of my life I shot firearms. I fully expected to be bothered by the noise but discovered I wasn't. When I concentrated on hitting a target neither the bang of my own rifle nor my neighbor's made any impression on me.

Firing a rifle at a stationary target, I found, was purely mechanical and required no skill, once you had properly zeroed in your sight—that is, you fired a shot after having brought the crosshairs on target. If you ended up a little to the right of bull's-eye, you adjusted the crosshairs a little to the left, and so on. Eventually you hit bull's-eye every time.

If they had let me count the shots only after I had zeroed in the sight I would have had a perfect score, but they insisted on counting the imperfect shots that took place in the course of adjusting the sight.